

FROM GREATNESS TO BETRAYAL

Alberta's Public Fall from Grace

1979 — 2026

A Cross-Party Record of What Was Built, and What Was Taken

PHASE TWO

The Getty Era • 1985 – 1992

The First Drawdown

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

St. Albert, Alberta • May 2026

The Getty Era, 1985 – 1992

Don Getty inherited Lougheed's Alberta. He did not get to keep it.

Of all the eras documented in this piece, the Getty era is the one most freighted with tragedy. Donald Ross Getty was Peter Lougheed's chosen successor, his friend, and the former Edmonton Eskimos quarterback who had served as Lougheed's Energy Minister and Intergovernmental Affairs Minister. He was one of the "Original Six" Progressive Conservative MLAs elected with Lougheed in 1967. He was — per the Government of Alberta's own biographical record — part of "a small core group that conceived the Heritage Savings Trust Fund" in 1976. He helped build the architecture this entire document is, in one way or another, the story of.

He also halted it. In 1987, during his sixth year as Premier, Getty's government stopped the transfer of 30% of provincial energy revenues to the Heritage Savings Trust Fund — the mechanism Lougheed had constructed to ensure that Alberta's non-renewable resource wealth would compound rather than be spent. The Fund has effectively flat-lined in real terms ever since. The decision was made under conditions of genuine fiscal crisis. It was also the structural beginning of the give-and-take pattern this document traces across the forty-seven years that followed.

The Getty era is not the era of dismantling. That distinction belongs to his successor. But the Getty era is the era in which the dismantling first became thinkable — when the Lougheed-era principle of reinvestment was, for the first time, overridden by the logic of current operating necessity. Every era that follows draws structurally on the precedent the Getty era established.

Political context

Donald Ross Getty was born August 30, 1933 in Westmount, Quebec. He graduated from the University of Western Ontario in 1955 and joined the Edmonton Eskimos as a quarterback the same year. He was named the Western CFL's "Outstanding Canadian" in 1959. He left professional football for the energy business, joining Imperial Oil in 1955 and rising through several oil and gas enterprises through the 1960s. In 1967 he was among the "Original Six" PC MLAs elected with Peter Lougheed, taking the Edmonton riding of Strathcona West. He served under Lougheed as Minister of Intergovernmental Affairs and Minister of Energy through the founding decade of the modern PC dynasty.

Getty left politics in 1979 for the private sector, taking board positions at Interprovincial Pipe and Steel Corporation, Genstar Corporation, Nova Corporation, and the Royal Bank of Canada. When Lougheed announced his retirement in 1985, Getty returned to win the PC leadership on the second ballot of a bitter contest. He was sworn in as Alberta's 11th Premier on November 1, 1985, at age 52.

The honeymoon ended almost immediately. In early 1986, the global oil market collapsed. OPEC, having spent two years defending high prices through production cuts, reversed course and flooded the market. Within months, the price of oil fell from approximately US\$27 per barrel in late 1985 to approximately US\$10 per barrel by mid-1986 — a decline of approximately 60% in a single fiscal year, with brief periods near US\$7. Alberta, whose entire fiscal model rested on royalty revenue from a commodity that had just lost three-fifths of its value, was structurally exposed.

The fiscal numbers tell the story of the era. The Government of Alberta posted a record \$3.3 billion deficit in 1986 — the first deficit of the modern PC era. Five more deficits followed in succession. By the time Getty left office in December 1992, accumulated provincial debt had reached approximately \$20 billion. The Heritage

Fund's assets, at that moment, totalled roughly \$12 billion. **The province's debt exceeded the value of its own savings fund.**

Getty's response combined three measures: tax increases, spending cuts across health, education, and social services, and — critically — the suspension of the 30% Heritage Fund transfer mechanism. The PC majority was reduced from 75 of 79 seats (Lougheed's 1982 high-water mark) to 61 of 83 seats in the May 1986 election, and reduced further in 1989. He did not seek a third term. Ralph Klein won the PC leadership in December 1992 on an explicit platform of more cuts, faster.

What the Getty government established for the disability community

The Getty government's positive contributions to disability-related policy were modest in scale but real. They occurred under fiscal conditions that made any new spending difficult, and they reflect the continued operation of the Lougheed-era institutional framework that Getty had inherited and could not fully fund.

1. The Brassard Review — "Claiming My Future" (1989)

Roy Brassard, MLA for Olds-Didsbury (elected in 1986) and then-Associate Minister of Family and Social Services, led a legislative review committee whose 1989 report — *Claiming My Future: A Person with a Mental Disability — Today and Tomorrow* — was the first major Alberta legislative review of developmental disability policy since the deinstitutionalisation movement began in the 1970s. The report is preserved in the academic record as a primary source (Sonpal-Valias, "History of Developmental Disability Policy in Alberta," School of Public Policy Publications, University of Calgary, 2019).

The Brassard Review's significance is historical rather than legislative — its recommendations did not produce immediate statutory change. But it represents the Getty government's continued public engagement with developmental disability policy during a period when no positive engagement was fiscally guaranteed. The review's framing — *claiming my future* — anticipates by three decades the community-led, person-first language now central to disability rights discourse.

2. Ministry of Seniors (1991)

In 1991, Premier Getty established a new, dedicated Ministry of Seniors — separating seniors' affairs from the broader Family and Social Services portfolio for the first time. Roy Brassard was named the inaugural Minister. The creation of a dedicated ministry was a structural acknowledgement that seniors' issues — many of which overlap with disability supports (cognitive decline, physical impairment, AISH transitions at age 65, long-term care) — deserved their own institutional home. The ministry has operated, under varying names and configurations, ever since.

3. Continued operation of AISH and the Lougheed-era disability framework

Within the documented record available to this campaign, the Getty government did not structurally reduce AISH benefits, freeze the program's base rate (those decisions are Klein-era), or remove appeal rights. AISH continued to operate on the architecture Lougheed had established. The Services for the Handicapped program continued. The Family Support for Children with Disabilities precursor programs continued.

This is consistent with the era's broader fiscal pattern: Getty reduced spending in discretionary lines (health, education, general social services) while preserving rights-based statutory programs whose costs flow from population eligibility rather than annual appropriation. Whether that pattern reflects principled protection of disability income or simply administrative inertia in a crisis-driven budget cycle is a question the documented record does not answer.

4. Family Day (1990) — broader civic context

Outside the disability-policy lens but worth noting for completeness: Getty created the statutory holiday of Family Day in 1990. It is a small civic legacy, and the Government of Alberta's own biographical materials emphasise it as a defining Getty-era achievement.

What the Getty government took or reduced

The Getty era's structural significance for this document — and for every era that follows — is concentrated in a single 1987 decision. Several additional reductions in health, education, and social services accompanied it. None of them, on the surface, directly targeted the disability community. All of them, in aggregate, established the fiscal and political precedent for everything that came afterward.

1. The 1987 Heritage Fund decision

From its founding in 1976 through fiscal 1986–87, the Alberta Heritage Savings Trust Fund had received an automatic transfer of 30% of provincial non-renewable resource revenues. The transfer was the structural mechanism by which the Fund grew. Lougheed had designed it specifically so that the Heritage Fund's growth would not be subject to the annual political fight over operating dollars; the transfer was law, not discretionary appropriation.

In 1987 — six years after his death, Lougheed's structural protection was overridden. The Getty government's response to the 1986 oil collapse and resulting deficits included a decision to suspend the 30% transfer. The mechanism was not formally abolished; it was suspended through subsequent budget actions, then never restored. The Globe and Mail, summarising the Fund's history in 2015, recorded the moment precisely:

"The Heritage Fund grew steadily through its first decade with an annual investment of 30 per cent of provincial energy revenues. In 1987 Premier Don Getty put a stop to the transfers and subsequent governments have spent largely all of Alberta's energy revenues. Despite strong investment returns and some small top-ups, the fund's value has essentially flat-lined."

— The Globe and Mail, "What happened to Alberta's cash stash," April 2015

The structural meaning of this decision cannot be overstated. The Heritage Fund peaked in real-term value at approximately \$24 billion in the early 1980s. By 2014 — twenty-seven years after Getty halted the transfers — the Fund had a market value of approximately \$15 billion in inflation-adjusted terms. Norway, whose oil-development model Lougheed had been the inspiration for, used the same period to grow its sovereign wealth fund to approximately US \$1 trillion by the end of 2017 (the year the Government Pension Fund Global passed the trillion-dollar threshold for the first time) and approximately US \$2 trillion by late 2025 (Norges Bank Investment Management; Government Pension Fund of Norway). The difference between \$15 billion and \$1 trillion in 2017 — let alone \$2 trillion today — is the cost, in real, generational, owed-to-Albertans dollars, of the 1987 decision and its successor decisions.

Lougheed spent the last decade of his life publicly criticising this trajectory. As documented in Phase One, he framed the drawdown as *"selling the house to pay for the groceries."* He did not name his successor by name. He did not need to. The math is unambiguous: the drawdown began in 1987, under Lougheed's chosen successor and personal friend, in response to an oil price collapse that the Heritage Fund had been specifically designed to insulate Alberta against.

THE STRUCTURAL POINT

The Heritage Fund is not an AISH program. But the philosophy that built the Heritage Fund — that wealth from a non-renewable source must be reinvested rather than spent on current operations — is the same philosophy that built AISH as an assured income outside the welfare system. When the Heritage Fund's reinvestment mechanism was suspended in 1987, the philosophy that protected AISH from being treated as a discretionary budget line was weakened in proportion. Every government that followed has drawn from both. The trajectories run in parallel.

2. Cuts to health, education, and social services (1986–1992)

Alongside the Heritage Fund decision, the Getty government imposed spending reductions across health, education, and social services, paired with tax increases, in successive budgets through 1986–1992. The specific quanta of each cut are documented in Alberta Treasury budget records of the era and have been summarised in Getty's obituary coverage:

As Global News summarised in its February 2016 obituary coverage: Getty led the province for seven years, with many highs and lows. He created Family Day in 1990, and was a strong advocate for senate reform. But finance was a constant issue during his tenure. The collapse in oil prices — from approximately US\$27 per barrel in late 1985 to approximately US\$10 by mid-1986 — forced Getty to put the brakes on spending. He raised taxes and imposed cuts in health, education, and social services; at the same time, he directed government resources toward supporting business.

The disability-policy significance of these cuts is indirect rather than direct. AISH itself was not targeted. But the broader social-services envelope from which AISH-adjacent supports flow — Family and Social Services operating budgets, the institutions that would later become PDD service providers, the Family Support for Children with Disabilities precursor framework — absorbed significant reductions during the Getty years. This is the documented record. The same record establishes that the institutional infrastructure around AISH was thinner when Getty left office than when he took it up — and the structural vulnerability he created became the basis for the more direct Klein-era reductions that followed.

3. The drawdown trajectory begins

The most consequential aspect of the Getty era for this piece is not any single decision but the establishment of a *pattern*: that under fiscal pressure, the Government of Alberta would draw down from Lougheed-era institutional savings rather than raise revenue to maintain them. The Heritage Fund halt was the first instance. The cuts to health, education, and social services were the second. The acceptance — by both government and the public — that this was the legitimate response to a revenue shock established the rhetorical and political conditions for the much larger reductions that began in 1992.

Lougheed's later critique of the drawdown is reproduced in Phase One of this piece. He spoke about resource policy explicitly. He did not, in any documented interview the campaign has located, name disability supports as a specific concern. But the principle he kept restating — that depleting wealth must be reinvested, not spent as current income — applies with equal force to social infrastructure. AISH was depleting wealth. Every subsequent reduction in AISH's real-term value has been the policy equivalent of *selling off the topsoil*.

Caseload context

AISH caseload data for the Getty era is sparse in publicly-available records, and the Open Alberta data series begins meaningfully in the 2000s. What can be established from departmental annual reports of the period (Alberta Family and Social Services, *Annual Report 1989–1990*; *Annual Report 1994–1995*) is that AISH continued to grow modestly through the late 1980s and into the early 1990s as the program matured and diagnostic categories broadened. The growth was not dramatic. The structural significance of the era is on the fiscal side, not the caseload side.

The Getty conclusion

Don Getty was a man of genuine personal integrity, by every account preserved in the documented record. His son Darin said at the time of his death: *"A son could not have had a better father."* Patrick Delaney, his former executive secretary, said: *"I don't think anybody saw the pending crisis with oil prices."* The University of Alberta awarded him an honorary Doctor of Laws degree in 2013 for his stewardship through the recession. Even Danielle Smith, the leader of the Alberta opposition at the time of his 2016 death, called him a man of great personal integrity.

This piece does not require those judgments to be wrong. It requires only that the documented record establish what was done — by whatever government, for whatever reason, with whatever moral character — and what the structural consequences for the disability community have been. The structural consequence of the Getty era is the 1987 Heritage Fund decision. It is the moment when the Lougheed-era principle of reinvestment was, for the first time, overridden by the logic of current necessity. Every era that follows draws on that precedent.

Getty himself appears not to have framed the 1987 decision as a break with Lougheed. The documented record suggests he understood it as a temporary suspension in response to a crisis he had not chosen and could not control. The temporariness, on his original framing, was the operating assumption. It was the governments that followed — Klein, Stelmach, Redford, the entire PC dynasty through 2015, and the UCP era thereafter — that made the suspension permanent. Getty halted the transfer. They never restored it.

Phase Three of this piece, when written, will document the era in which the drawdown stopped being a fiscal response and became a political project. **Ralph Klein took office in December 1992 on the explicit promise of doing more of what Getty had done — faster, deeper, and as policy rather than as crisis management.** The disability community, having survived the Getty era without direct programmatic reductions, would not survive the Klein era the same way.

Bibliography — Phase Two sources

Sources specific to or directly underpinning the Getty-era chapter. To be merged with the Phase One bibliography seed and subsequent phase bibliographies when the full document is assembled.

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